The churches, including the Catholic Bishops' Conference of India, fought back, saying they had co-existed peacefully in the country for centuries and that a 'deliberate attempt' was being made to 'ignore the Constitution', with 'extremist elements' attacking 'Christians with impunity even with the help of the authorities'.[38] Church groups argued that they were being unfairly maligned for political reasons.[39]

Nehru initially reacted to the attacks on Christian missionaries by clarifying governmental policy, saying that, while there would be no religious interference by the Indian state, it had a pressing political and security imperative for imposing controls in border areas. There were nine foreign missions in border areas at the time, said the government. Nehru announced that no new ones would be allowed, though there would be no restrictions on indigenous Christian missions.[40]

Yet, he was entirely sensitive to the impact this controversy could have on Indian Christians, their right to equality and perceptions of bias. Much like he had done in his 1951 speech in Nasik when faced with a similar debate, Nehru now despatched a powerful letter as Congress president in his monthly circular to state Congress Committees. The prime minister argued that, while he personally disapproved of conversion, he was equally opposed to the counter Hindu 'Shuddhi' movement. He said that while he had imposed controls on foreigners only in border areas, the debate on conversion could not but have an impact on Indian Christians. In his clearest enunciation yet of what he meant by a 'secular' state, Nehru told Congressmen that it signified an 'equal' space where 'minority communities' were free to practise their religion. Furthermore, he wrote, the 'majority community' should 'fully realise it' and not use its 'dominant position in any way which might prejudice our secular ideal'. If organisations talking of a 'Hindu Rashtra' triumphed, he said, it would be 'neither nationalism nor democracy'. It would be a 'throwback to some ideas of a medieval period', thundered Nehru. A majority's dominance as a 'religious community' would be 'totally undemocratic', he argued, because there was 'no chance of a minority gaining this position in a democratic set-up'.[41] It was yet another episode in the long-standing face-off between Nehru and his